Archive of Pain: Modeling Systems Where Suffering Is the Archive

I. Introduction: Theorizing Pain as Infrastructure and Suffering as Archive

A. Conceptual Framework: Defining "Pain as Infrastructure" and "Suffering as Archive"

This report endeavors to develop a conceptual framework wherein "Pain as Infrastructure" and "Suffering as Archive" serve as analytical lenses to examine the underpinnings of historical imperial systems. The premise of "Pain as Infrastructure" is that certain complex societal structures, particularly empires, are not merely characterized by the incidental occurrence of suffering among their populations. Instead, these systems are, to varying degrees, structurally reliant on the systematic production, meticulous management, and instrumentalization of pain—be it physical, psychological, or epistemic—for their very establishment, maintenance, consolidation of control, and expansion. Pain, in this model, transcends its common understanding as a negative externality of power; it becomes a foundational, often invisible, yet critical load-bearing element that enables the functioning of the imperial apparatus. This includes the pain of coerced labor, the trauma of conquest and displacement, the psychological duress of surveillance and control, and the epistemic violence of cultural and knowledge system erasure.

Complementing this, "Suffering as Archive" posits that the systemic suffering generated by such infrastructures is not an ephemeral or transient phenomenon. Rather, it is encoded, preserved, and transmitted across generations, forming a durable, though frequently suppressed or deliberately obscured, record. This archive is multifaceted, manifesting not only in conventional textual records but also in material culture, such as the *quipu* of the Inca, which documented tribute often extracted through coercive labor.[1] More profoundly, this archive resides within embodied memory, where individual and collective trauma leaves physiological and psychological imprints.[3] Somatic experiences, the physical sensations tied to oppression or extreme exertion, become part of this living archive.[5] Furthermore, suffering is archived in oral traditions, cultural practices that carry the weight of past hardships, and even in the conspicuous silences and erasures within dominant historical narratives, a testament to epistemicide.[2] The neurobiological underpinnings of pain and memory suggest that experiences of suffering can become deeply embedded, influencing cognitive processes and future behavior, thus forming a persistent archive within the very fabric of individuals and communities.[8]

The interplay between "Pain as Infrastructure" and "Suffering as Archive" is dynamic and cyclical. The infrastructures of pain generate widespread suffering, which, once archived in these diverse forms, can serve to reinforce and perpetuate the very systems that produced it. For instance, the memory of punishment can ensure compliance, or the normalization of certain hardships can sustain exploitative labor systems. Understanding this interplay is crucial for a more profound comprehension of how power operates and how its consequences endure. The destruction of knowledge systems, such as the Incan *quipu*, represents a violent act of erasing one form of archive, while simultaneously creating another—an archive of loss, epistemic pain, and the enduring trauma of cultural suppression.[2]

B. Overview of Comparative Case Studies (Inca, Roman, Ottoman Empires)

To explore and substantiate this theoretical model, this report will undertake a comparative analysis of three distinct historical empires: the Inca, the Roman, and the Ottoman. Each of these empires, despite their unique

geographical, cultural, and temporal contexts, developed and relied upon sophisticated systems of governance, labor extraction, information management, and social control that demonstrably involved the institutionalization of various forms of pain and the creation of corresponding archives of suffering.

For the **Inca Empire**, the analysis will focus on the *Mita* labor system as an infrastructure of pain, where the physical exertion and hardship of conscripted labor were fundamental to imperial projects.[11] The *quipu* system will be examined as an archive that, while ostensibly administrative, indirectly chronicled this labor and, through its systematic destruction by Spanish colonizers, became an archive of profound epistemic pain.[2] The *chasqui* messenger system, vital for imperial communication, will be explored in terms of the somatic toll on its runners, whose bodies became archives of imperial urgency and control.[13]

In the context of the **Roman Empire**, the report will investigate the "spectacle of pain" in arenas and triumphal processions as a deliberate infrastructure for reinforcing imperial authority and social hierarchies.[15] The pain of conquest and the suffering of enslaved populations, whose labor underpinned Roman economic and monumental achievements through systems like *corvée* labor [16], will be considered as archived in the very fabric of Roman society and its material remains.

For the **Ottoman Empire**, the analysis will touch upon the pain inherent in systems like the *devşirme*, the levy of boys for the Janissary corps, which, while creating an elite military force, inflicted deep communal and familial suffering.[18] The psychological weight of a rigid imperial order, maintained through elaborate ceremonies, a distinct urban soundscape, and the visible manifestations of power in Istanbul, will be examined as an infrastructure of control, with its effects archived in the collective memory and social practices of its diverse populace.[19]

By comparing these diverse imperial formations, this report aims to identify both common structural patterns in the institutionalization and archiving of pain, as well as culturally specific manifestations. This comparative approach will serve to test the robustness and broaden the applicability of the "Pain as Infrastructure" and "Suffering as Archive" model. While all three empires relied on forms of coercive power and labor, the specific mechanisms through which this pain was integrated into the state apparatus, and subsequently remembered, embodied, or erased, offer rich material for comparative analysis.

C. The Role of Somatic Experience and Sensory Perception in Understanding These Archives

A critical dimension of this report is the emphasis on somatic experience and sensory perception as indispensable tools for understanding these unconventional archives of suffering. Traditional archival research often prioritizes textual evidence, but archives of suffering, as conceptualized here, are frequently non-textual and are deeply embedded within the body and collective sensory experience.[3] Somatic memory, the body's capacity to retain imprints of past experiences, particularly traumatic ones, serves as a living archive.[5] The discipline of sensory history, which explores how past peoples experienced the world through their senses, provides a methodological avenue to access these embodied archives.

The experience of imperial power, for instance, was rarely an abstract or purely intellectual encounter. It was profoundly sensory: the awe or intimidation inspired by the sight of monumental Roman architecture [21], the distinct sounds of Ottoman military bands or the public proclamation of decrees in Istanbul [19], the smell of incense during Inca religious ceremonies or the taste of ritually distributed *chicha*.[24] Similarly, the suffering inflicted by these empires was experienced viscerally – the physical pain of forced labor, the fear induced by public punishments, the

disorientation of cultural loss.

By attending to these somatic and sensory dimensions, this report seeks to move beyond a purely structural or textual analysis of imperial systems. It aims to access a more holistic understanding of how power was lived, how pain was inflicted and endured, and how these experiences became archived within the very bodies and sensory worlds of imperial subjects.[8] This approach is particularly crucial when dealing with societies like the Inca, whose primary archival system, the *quipu*, was itself a tactile, visual, and possibly kinesthetic medium, the full understanding of which has been lost due to colonial epistemicide.[26] The suffering inherent in such systems is not merely recorded *in* the archive; it *is* the archive, inscribed in flesh, memory, and landscape.

II. The Inca Empire: Knotted Legacies of Labor and Loss

The Inca Empire, or *Tawantinsuyu*, represents a compelling case study for examining pain as infrastructure and suffering as an archive. Its sophisticated systems of administration, communication, and labor mobilization, while enabling vast territorial control and impressive material achievements, were often underpinned by coercive practices and the imposition of hardship on its populace. The subsequent Spanish conquest and the systematic dismantling of Inca knowledge systems further layered new dimensions of suffering, creating an archive of loss that continues to resonate.

A. The Quipu System: An Archive of Data, Labor, and Loss

The *quipu* (or *khipu*) stands as a primary example of an Inca archive, a complex system of knotted and colored cords used for recording a vast array of information.[1] Typically constructed from cotton or camelid fibers, *quipus* featured a main primary cord from which numerous pendant cords—and sometimes subsidiary cords—were suspended.[26] Information was encoded through a combination of knot types (simple, long, figure-eight), their position on the cords (indicating a base-10 positional system), the direction of ply and knotting, the colors of the cords, and even the types of fibers used.[2] While the numerical aspects of *quipus*, used for accounting, census data, tribute tallies, and calendrical information, are relatively well understood [1], scholars like Gary Urton have proposed that they might also have encoded logographic or phonological data, suggesting a capacity for narrative or historical records.[1] Indeed, colonial chroniclers noted their use for recording laws, genealogies, and history, distinguishing between numerical and narrative *quipus*.[7] Some estimates suggest up to a third of extant *quipus* may carry such non-numerical information.[26]

The creation and interpretation of these intricate records were the domain of specialists known as *Quipucamayocs* (*khipu kamayuq*, "khipu-authority").[2] These individuals, often male and of a specific age group (fifty to sixty, according to Guaman Poma [2]), underwent rigorous training, possibly for years, to master the complex codes.[11] This knowledge was often hereditary, passed down through generations, ensuring the continuity of the archival system.[7] The *Quipucamayocs* were not mere accountants; they were the historians, administrators, and memory keepers of the empire, capable of "reading" the *quipus* with remarkable accuracy, sometimes even with their eyes closed, implying a profound tactile and mnemonic engagement with the cords.[2] They could be summoned to colonial courts where their *quipu*-based bookkeeping was recognized as valid documentation.[2]

The *quipu* system, in its meticulous tracking of resources, labor obligations (*Mita*), and census data, served as a direct instrument of imperial control.[2] The numbers and categories recorded on the *quipus* represented the empire's wealth and manpower, much of which was extracted through systems that inherently involved hardship and coercion. Thus, the *quipu* functioned as a dual archive: overtly, it was a sophisticated administrative tool;

covertly, it documented the human cost—the suffering—entailed in generating imperial surplus and maintaining state projects.

The arrival of the Spanish heralded a catastrophic epistemicide. Driven by a desire to eradicate indigenous religious practices and consolidate their own power, Spanish authorities, particularly following the decrees of the Third Council of Lima in 1583, ordered the destruction of *quipus*.[2] These "talking knots" were deemed idolatrous objects, particularly those containing information on "ancient superstition," "rites, ceremonies and laws".[2] While the Council encouraged the use of *quipus* for Christian confessions and doctrinal memorization, distinguishing them from those preserving pre-Christian traditions [38], the overarching policy was one of suppression. Thousands of *quipus* were burned or otherwise destroyed [7], and *Quipucamayocs* were persecuted, forced to renounce their craft to avoid severe punishment.[41] This systematic destruction was not merely the loss of records; it was the violent erasure of an entire knowledge system, an act of cultural and intellectual annihilation that inflicted profound and lasting pain. The "Inca viewpoint" on their own world, as Urton notes, was imperiled, with *quipus* being the only primary sources from their perspective.[42]

Colonial-era chroniclers like Felipe Guaman Poma de Ayala, in his *Primer nueva corónica y buen gobierno*, and Inca Garcilaso de la Vega, in his *Comentarios Reales de los Incas*, provide invaluable, albeit complex and often filtered, testimonies to the nature of *quipu* knowledge and the devastating impact of its loss.[10] Guaman Poma's illustrations, for instance, depict *Quipucamayocs* with their instruments, underscoring their integral role in Inca administration.[10] Garcilaso, drawing on his Inca heritage and childhood memories, described how *quipus* recorded not just numbers but also historical accounts and royal speeches, with *Quipucamayocs* and *amautas* (philosophers) preserving these narratives.[45] He recounts how his mother's relatives would bring *quipus* to be transcribed, fearing the Spaniards would not understand them, highlighting the active process of knowledge loss and the anxiety it produced.[49]

The specialized knowledge of the *Quipucamayocs*, likely involving a sophisticated interplay of tactile, visual, and mnemonic skills, constituted an embodied archive. The ability to interpret the intricate system of knots, colors, cord ply, and spatial arrangements was not merely cognitive but deeply ingrained through years of practice and, often, hereditary transmission.[2] The persecution of these specialists and the suppression of their craft led to the loss of this living, somatic tradition of knowledge. This epistemic violence represents a profound form of suffering—not just the physical danger faced by the *Quipucamayocs*, but the erasure of a unique, embodied way of knowing and recording the world. The "ghost" of this lost knowledge, and the persistent "mythogenesis surrounding lost quipu knowledge" [2], fuel modern efforts to decipher the remaining ~1400 pre-Columbian *quipus*.[2] These endeavors, utilizing computational analysis and searching for "Rosetta Stone" equivalents [26], are attempts to recover fragments from this damaged archive, a testament to the enduring pain of cultural severance and the ongoing quest to understand what was lost.

B. The Chasqui Messenger System: Embodying Imperial Communication and Its Toll

The *chasqui* system was the arterial network of the Inca Empire, a sophisticated relay of runners responsible for the rapid transmission of information and lightweight valuables across the vast and geographically challenging Andean domain.[26] These messengers traversed the extensive *Qhapaq Ñan*, the Inca road system, connecting the capital Cusco to the farthest reaches of the *Tawantinsuyu*.[63] *Chasquis* carried both memorized oral messages and physical *quipus*, ensuring that the administrative, military, and potentially narrative data encoded in the knotted

cords reached their destinations with remarkable speed.[2]

The life of a *chasqui* was one of extreme physical demand and constant somatic stress. Selected from a young age, often from loyal *curaca* (local chief) families, for their athletic physique, exceptional lung capacity, and ability to run fast, they underwent rigorous and continuous training.[11] This training included running up and down hills to build stamina and speed on slopes, racing against each other, and developing splayed toes for better grip on uneven terrain.[13] They operated in a relay, with *chaskiwasis* (relay stations) strategically placed approximately every 1.4 to 2.5 kilometers (or roughly half a league to a league, though distances varied) along the roads.[11] A *chasqui* would run at top speed to the next station, where a fresh runner would be waiting, alerted by the sound of the incoming runner's *pututu* (conch shell trumpet).[11] This system allowed messages to travel up to 240-320 kilometers per day.[11] To manage the immense fatigue, hunger, and the challenges of high altitude and harsh climates, *chasquis* were among the few individuals in the empire permitted to chew coca leaves, considered a sacred plant that provided energy and dulled pain.[71] The very bodies of the *chasquis*, conditioned by this relentless exertion and sustained by coca, became living archives of the empire's demand for constant, rapid communication.

The psychological stress on *chasquis* was equally significant. The accurate memorization and faithful relay of oral messages were paramount, as any distortion could have severe consequences for imperial administration or military operations.[11] Chroniclers report that the punishment for delivering a message incorrectly was exceptionally severe; for example, a *chasqui* could be thrown off a cliff.[13] This constant threat of death, known from childhood, constituted a profound form of pain integral to the system's efficacy. The *chasqui's* existence was thus a continuous navigation of physical limits and psychological pressure, their discipline reinforced by the ultimate sanction. This system, where pain and the risk of death ensured fidelity, made the *chasqui* a direct instrument and embodied archive of imperial will. Their job was so crucial that they were exempt from other *mit'a* labor obligations like farming or mining.[11] They were housed, fed, and clothed by the state, their sustenance drawn from imperial storehouses (*tambos*).[13]

The Inca civil war between Huascar and Atahualpa, and the subsequent Spanish conquest, severely disrupted this finely tuned communication infrastructure.[28] While the Spanish were initially impressed by the efficiency of the *chasqui* system, even utilizing it for their own communications as it was deemed faster than horse-mounted messengers in the rugged Andean terrain [11], the system eventually declined under colonial rule.[68] The dismantling of Inca authority, the depopulation due to disease and conflict, and the shift in economic priorities led to the decay of the *Qhapaq Ñan* and its support structures.[63] This transition itself—from an indigenous system of rapid communication vital for imperial cohesion to a decaying and repurposed network under foreign rule—forms an archive of colonial imposition and the suffering of disrupted indigenous lifeways.

The arrival of a *chasqui*, heralded by the *pututu* and marked by distinctive attire (such as a white feather sunshade for visibility [62]), created a specific sensory signature that pulsed across the empire. This rhythmic flow of information was a constant reminder of imperial presence and authority. The silencing of the *pututu* and the disappearance of the *chasqui* from the roads would have been a palpable, sensory indicator of the old order's collapse, archiving the pain of disconnection and the imposition of a new, alien power.

C. Mita Labor and Imperial Infrastructure: The Land as an Archive of Toil

The *Mita* system was the bedrock of the Inca imperial economy and its capacity for monumental construction.[12] It was a form of rotational, obligatory public service where adult males from subjugated communities contributed labor for a set period each year to state projects.[11] This labor was not compensated with wages in a monetary

economy but through a system of reciprocity where the state, in theory, provided for the welfare of its subjects, including sustenance from state storehouses (*qollqas*) during their service.[12] The *Mita* fueled a wide range of imperial endeavors: agriculture on state and religious lands, mining, military service, and, crucially, the construction and maintenance of the empire's vast infrastructure, including the *Qhapaq Ñan*, *tambos*, *qollqas*, temples, and administrative centers.[11] This system, while enabling the empire's expansion and grandeur, was fundamentally built upon the organized and often arduous labor, a form of institutionalized suffering, of its populace.

The *Qhapaq Ñan*, an engineering marvel stretching over 40,000 kilometers, with its meticulously paved sections, stairways, bridges, and drainage systems, stands as a primary testament to *Mita* labor.[63] Along these roads, *tambos* were constructed at regular intervals (roughly a day's journey apart) to provide lodging, food, and supplies for state personnel, armies, and *chasquis*.[14] *Qollqas*, strategically located storehouses, often built on hillsides with sophisticated ventilation systems, held vast quantities of agricultural produce (like maize and potatoes), textiles, and other goods generated by *Mita* labor and tribute.[86] More than ten thousand such storehouses dotted the empire, forming a critical part of its economic and logistical backbone.[91]

The physical existence of this extensive infrastructure—roads carved into mountainsides, massive stone walls erected with precision, terraces transforming steep slopes into arable land—forms a tangible archive of the collective human energy, skill, and endurance expended under the *Mita* system. The very landscape of the Andes was reshaped by this labor. These are not merely functional structures; they are imbued with the somatic experiences—the toil, the hardship, the displacement, the potential injuries, and the sheer physical exertion—of countless individuals over generations. The archaeological remains of these sites, from the grand administrative centers like Huánuco Pampa [13] to the humble *tambos*, are silent witnesses to this pain-fueled construction. The monumental scale and engineering prowess displayed, for example at Sacsayhuamán with its massive, perfectly fitted stones [102], were intended to project Inca power and divine mandate, but they also stand as an undeniable record of the immense human cost involved in their creation. The landscape itself, therefore, becomes a vast somatic archive, where the pain of labor is literally inscribed into the earth and stone, a permanent testament to the foundational role of organized suffering in the Inca imperium.

D. The Somatic Archive of Colonialism: Enduring Pain from Suppression

The Spanish conquest initiated a new era of suffering for the Andean peoples, layering fresh trauma upon the existing imperial structures. The violent overthrow of the Inca state, the imposition of a foreign religion and administration, the catastrophic demographic collapse due to European diseases and warfare, and the intensification of resource extraction created a profound and lasting somatic archive of colonialism.[43]

The deliberate epistemicide enacted by the Spanish, particularly the destruction of *quipus* and the persecution of *Quipucamayocs*, was a core component of this colonial pain infrastructure.[2] This was not merely the loss of an accounting system but the severance of a vital cultural artery, a unique way of knowing, remembering, and transmitting history, law, and cosmology.[2] The pain of this loss is not confined to the historical moment of destruction but endures in the ongoing condition of not knowing, of having a significant part of one's heritage violently erased and rendered largely illegible. The "secret" of the *quipu*, once a source of Inca power and organization, became a symbol of colonial rupture and indigenous suffering.

Despite this systematic suppression, traces of *quipu* knowledge and practice persisted in some Andean communities for centuries, sometimes in hybrid forms like "khipu boards" which combined knotted cords with alphabetic script.[31] Anthropological research by scholars such as Frank Salomon and Sabine Hyland has illuminated the resilience of these cord-keeping traditions and their continued significance in ritual and communal

life, representing a form of "resilient archiving".[7] These surviving practices, often imbued with somatic and sensory elements—the tactile engagement with the cords, the visual recognition of patterns, the oral traditions accompanying their interpretation—can be understood as a testament to the enduring archive of suffering and the persistent effort to maintain cultural identity in the face of overwhelming colonial pressure. The "feeling" of the cords, as Hyland notes in relation to the Collata *khipus* [122], underscores the somatic dimension of this knowledge. The continued curation of *quipus* as patrimonial objects in some villages [31] speaks to their power as archives of memory and identity, even when their original "literacy" has been largely lost. This persistence is itself a form of enduring the pain of epistemic violence and striving to make sense of a fractured past.

III. The Roman Empire: Spectacles of Suffering, Structures of Dominance

The Roman Empire, renowned for its military prowess, sophisticated legal systems, and monumental architecture, also provides a stark illustration of how pain and suffering were integral to its infrastructure and how these experiences were archived and broadcast to its populace. From the grand spectacles of the arena to the very stones of its buildings and roads, Rome constructed a powerful narrative of dominance that was often written in the currency of suffering.

A. Architecture as Imperial Imprint: The Material Archive of Power and Labor

Roman monumental architecture served as a pervasive and enduring visual and spatial manifestation of imperial power, order, and engineering supremacy.[7] The "Roman architectural revolution," fueled by the mastery of Roman concrete (*opus caementicium*), arches, and domes, allowed for the construction of structures on an unprecedented scale and with innovative designs.[7] Buildings like the Forum Romanum, the Colosseum, imperial temples, basilicas, vast aqueduct systems, and public baths were not merely functional; they were potent symbols of Rome's capacity to command resources, organize labor, and impose its vision upon the landscape.[22]

The construction of this vast infrastructure often relied on systems of *corvée* labor (*opera publica*), where citizens and conquered peoples were compelled to provide unpaid work for state projects, particularly road and bridge building.[16] While Roman citizens in the later Empire might perform *opera publica* in lieu of taxes, the burden often fell heavily on provincial populations and slaves. These monumental structures, therefore, stand as a material archive of this coerced labor, embodying the physical exertion and hardship of those who built them. The rhythmic, often grueling, demands of such labor were a constant feature of imperial expansion and maintenance, a somatic reality for a significant portion of the empire's population. Gottfried Semper's observation that Roman architecture represented "the idea of world domination expressed in stone" encapsulates this fusion of material form and imperial ideology.[22]

For the diverse populace of the empire, including commoners (plebeians) and provincials, the sensory experience of Roman urban environments was overwhelmingly shaped by this imperial architecture.[147] The grandeur and ubiquity of these structures—the imposing facades of temples, the vastness of the Colosseum, the orderly grid of city streets converging on the central Forum—were designed to inspire awe, communicate Roman order, and underscore the permanence of imperial rule.[22] The Forum, as the religious, administrative, legal, and commercial heart of Roman cities, was a particularly potent space where imperial power was concentrated and made visible through its temples, basilicas, statues, and inscriptions.[67] The constant visual and spatial reinforcement of Roman authority aimed to normalize imperial dominance, making it an inescapable part of daily life and collective consciousness. The very stones of empire, often quarried and transported through immense suffering, became the

silent, enduring archive of the power that commanded such labor and the pain inherent in its execution.

B. Ritualized Violence and Sustenance: The Imperial Spectacle and its Somatic Archive

The Roman state masterfully employed public spectacles, often involving ritualized violence and the distribution of sustenance, as a core component of its infrastructure of power and social control. These events created a potent somatic archive, deeply impressing imperial ideology upon the populace through intense sensory experiences.

Roman Triumphal Processions were elaborate ceremonies celebrating military victories, meticulously designed to showcase the might of Rome and the glory of its commanders.[15] The *vir triumphalis* (triumphing general), adorned in regal attire (laurel crown, purple and gold *toga picta*) and riding a four-horse chariot, embodied near-divine authority.[15] The procession was a multi-sensory onslaught: the visual display of captured spoils—weapons, treasures, exotic items—and paraded captives, often in chains, vividly demonstrated Roman dominance and the suffering of the defeated.[15] The sounds of soldiers chanting "*io triumphe!*" and singing ribald songs, accompanied by music, filled the air as the procession moved along a sacred route through Rome, culminating in sacrifices to Jupiter Capitolinus.[15] Subsequent feasting and games, sponsored by the general, extended the celebration and reinforced his beneficence.[15] The suffering of the vanquished, publicly displayed and ritualized, became a central element in this archive of Roman victory and power, consumed by the populace and reinforcing the legitimacy of imperial expansion.

Gladiatorial games (*munera*) and chariot races (*ludi circenses*) were another cornerstone of Roman public life and imperial control, famously encapsulated by Juvenal's phrase "*panem et circenses*" (bread and circuses).[148] These state-sponsored entertainments, often free to the public, served to placate the urban masses and project an image of imperial generosity and power.[149] The Colosseum and Circus Maximus were architectural marvels designed to host these spectacles, creating immersive sensory environments for tens of thousands of spectators.[149] The sights of combat, the roar of the crowd, the smell of blood and exotic animals, and the thrill of the races constituted a powerful, visceral experience for commoners.[149] The pain and death on display in the arena were not merely entertainment but a ritualized demonstration of Roman control over life and death, reinforcing social hierarchies and the state's capacity for violence. This spectacular suffering became a regularly consumed archive, normalizing violence as an instrument of state power and imperial ideology.

The Annona system, responsible for the procurement and distribution of grain and other essential commodities to the city of Rome and the army, represented an infrastructure of sustenance that was also deeply intertwined with imperial power and control.[188] By ensuring a stable food supply, particularly for the vast urban population of Rome, the state maintained social order and fostered dependency.[188] The free or subsidized distribution of grain was a tangible manifestation of imperial benevolence, but it also underscored the populace's reliance on the emperor and the state apparatus. The fear of hunger, and the relief provided by the Annona, created a somatic archive of imperial provision and, subtly, of control. Ritual feasting associated with state religious practices and the imperial cult further reinforced this relationship, where the sharing of sacred meals, often involving sacrifices, symbolized the bond between the people, the state, and the gods, with the emperor frequently positioned as the chief benefactor and intermediary.[190] The suffering inherent in the agricultural labor that produced these supplies, often performed by slaves or coerced provincials, remained largely invisible to the urban recipients but was nonetheless a foundational element of this system.

C. Auditory and Visual Semiotics of Power: The Sensory Language of Roman

Authority

The Roman state cultivated a pervasive sensory environment where symbols of imperial authority were constantly communicated through visual and auditory channels, embedding the presence of power into the daily lives of its subjects. This created an ambient, multi-sensory archive of Roman ideology and control.

The Roman military, a cornerstone of imperial power, employed potent visual symbols. The legionary eagle standard, the *Aquila*, was paramount.[192] More than just an emblem, the *Aquila* represented the honor, spirit, and power of the legion and, by extension, Rome itself. It was a sacred object, and its loss in battle was considered the ultimate humiliation, often prompting extensive military campaigns for its recovery.[192] For the Roman soldier, the sight of the *Aquila* instilled discipline, loyalty, and a sense of collective identity; for conquered peoples or adversaries, it was a formidable symbol of Roman military might.[192] Other standards, such as the *vexillum* (flag for specific units) and the *signum* (standard for a century), further articulated the army's hierarchical structure and operational cohesion.[194]

Imperial coinage was another ubiquitous medium for disseminating visual propaganda.[195] Coins, passing through countless hands in daily transactions, carried the portrait of the reigning emperor on the obverse, a constant reminder of his authority and presence throughout the vast empire.[195] The reverse of coins often depicted symbols of Roman power, such as the eagle perched on a globe signifying imperial dominion, scenes of military victories, personifications of virtues attributed to the emperor (e.g., *Pax*, *Victoria*), or depictions of deities, linking imperial rule with divine sanction.[195] These miniature, mobile archives of imperial ideology reached all levels of society, reinforcing the emperor's image and the state's narratives.

The promulgation of laws and imperial edicts was managed to ensure both audibility and visibility of Roman authority. Edicts, particularly those of magistrates like praetors, were read aloud publicly.[196] They were also inscribed on whitened wooden boards (*alba*) with black letters and red headings (*rubricae*) for section titles, and displayed in public spaces like the Forum.[196] This ensured that imperial commands were accessible, at least visually, to the populace. Legal experts would often be present near these displayed edicts to offer interpretations, indicating active public engagement with these pronouncements.[196] Inscriptions on public monuments also served to publicize laws and commemorate imperial achievements, turning the urban landscape itself into an archive of Roman law and history.[134]

The auditory landscape of Roman military power was further defined by the sounds of its trumpets. Instruments like the *cornu* (a large, curved horn), the *tuba* (a straight trumpet), and the *buccina* (a smaller horn) were used to signal orders in battle (charge, retreat, assembly) and for ceremonial purposes.[198] The distinct, powerful sounds of these instruments created an auditory signature of Roman military discipline and organization, capable of conveying commands over the noise of battle and instilling awe or fear. The *classicum*, a particular sound of the *buccina*, was specifically appropriated to the commander-in-chief, audibly marking his authority.[198] This carefully managed soundscape was integral to military effectiveness and the projection of power. The pain associated with this sensory propaganda was often the subtle coercion inherent in the omnipresence of imperial symbols and the suppression of alternative voices or signs of resistance.

IV. The Ottoman Empire: The Weight of Order and the Echoes of Control

The Ottoman Empire, spanning centuries and vast territories, developed sophisticated mechanisms for projecting

power and maintaining social order. These mechanisms were deeply embedded in ceremonial practices, urban design, auditory cues, and systems of sustenance and control, all of which contributed to an infrastructure of power that, in various ways, involved or archived suffering.

A. Ceremonial Infrastructure: Somatic Rhythms of Imperial Display

Public ceremonies were a cornerstone of Ottoman imperial display, functioning as a vital infrastructure for communicating power, reinforcing social hierarchies, and shaping the collective experience of the diverse populace, particularly in the capital, Istanbul.[20] These events, often centered around the Sultan and the imperial palace, included military processions, the ceremonial departure of the Hajj caravan (*Surre Alayı*), celebrations of holy days and religious festivals (like Ramadan and Eid), royal events such as weddings, births, and circumcision feasts for princes, state funerals, the sword-girding ceremony marking a new Sultan's accession, and the regular Friday Processions of the Sultan to a mosque for prayer.[20]

These ceremonies served multiple functions: they were a means of direct and symbolic **communication** with the populace, allowing the Sultan to be seen and for subjects to (at times) present petitions [20]; they provided **entertainment** for city residents, often involving elaborate spectacles, music, and feasts [20]; they **revivified social and religious life**, reinforcing communal bonds and religious piety [20]; and, crucially, they were designed to **display the magnanimity, power, and wealth of the Sultan** and the Ottoman state.[20] The grandeur of these events was intended to create a "psychology of submission" among the subjects.[210]

Somatic elements were central to these displays. Coordinated movements, such as the precise order of processions with participants arrayed according to rank, visually reinforced the imperial hierarchy.[20] The Sultan's mode of transport was highly symbolic; for sea excursions, specially designed and opulently decorated *saltanat kayık* (Sultan's rowboats) were used, their arrival often announced by cannon fire.[20] Elaborate costumes, particularly the ceremonial kaftans of the Sultan and high officials, made from luxurious fabrics like silk and brocade, adorned with gold embroidery and fur trim, signified rank, wealth, and the splendor of the court.[25] Banners and military standards, including the distinctive horse-tail *tughs*, were prominent in processions, visually asserting military and imperial authority.[218] Music, especially from the Mehter bands, provided a powerful auditory component to these events.[23] The meticulous choreography, specific attire indicating rank, and controlled access inherent in Ottoman imperial ceremonies functioned as a living, embodied archive of the empire's complex social and political hierarchy. Participation in, and observation of, these rituals inscribed these power relations onto the bodies and memories of the populace. The repetitive nature of many ceremonies, like the Friday Processions, created a "somatic rhythm" of imperial presence, constantly reinforcing the established order. The "pain" element here is subtle, embedded in the coercive maintenance of an unequal power structure and the psychological weight of such omnipresent displays of authority.

B. Architectural and Urban Semiotics: Istanbul as an Imperial Sensorium

The urban landscape of Ottoman Istanbul, particularly its imperial and religious architecture, was a carefully constructed stage for the projection of power and the shaping of collective identity. The Topkapi Palace, the primary imperial residence and administrative center for centuries, exemplified this through its hierarchical layout.[20] Its successive courtyards—from the First Court (Alay Meydanı), accessible to the public and used for large ceremonies, to the Second Court (Divan Meydanı), housing the Imperial Council and state affairs, and finally the Third Court (Enderun) and Harem, the Sultan's private domain—created a spatial progression that mirrored and reinforced the imperial hierarchy.[199] Access became increasingly restricted, visually and physically communicating the sacredness and remoteness of the Sultan's power. Opulent decoration, including Iznik tiles and elaborate

calligraphy, further underscored the wealth and sophistication of the Ottoman court.[229]

Imperial mosques, such as the Süleymaniye Mosque (commissioned by Süleyman the Magnificent) and the Sultan Ahmed Mosque (Blue Mosque), dominated Istanbul's skyline, serving as potent visual symbols of the Sultan's piety and the state's religious authority.[23] Their strategic placement on prominent hills, massive domes, slender minarets, and expansive courtyards were designed to inspire awe and visually assert Ottoman presence and Islamic identity.[23] The interiors, often filled with the sounds of Qur'anic recitation and the scent of incense, created a rich sensory environment intended to evoke Paradise and reinforce spiritual devotion.[203] These mosques were typically part of larger *külliye* complexes, which included schools, hospitals, and public kitchens (*imarets*), demonstrating the Sultan's role as a provider for his subjects and further integrating imperial power into the urban fabric.[23]

Public fountains (*sebils*), often elaborately decorated with calligraphy and intricate designs, were also common features in Ottoman cities, providing essential water while simultaneously serving as visible reminders of imperial benevolence and aesthetic refinement.[20] Calligraphic inscriptions, particularly the Sultan's *tughra* (imperial monogram) on buildings, documents, and coins, functioned as a ubiquitous imperial signature, asserting authority and legitimacy.[212] The urban fabric of Istanbul thus became an archive of power and, for some, exclusion. While Muslims might experience this imperial sensorium as an affirmation of their dominant cultural and religious identity, non-Muslim communities, though "tolerated" under the *millet* system [99], would have experienced this landscape as a constant reminder of their subordinate status and the limits of their inclusion. The very "tolerance" afforded to them was an instrument of imperial control, and the omnipresent symbols of Islamic Ottoman rule constituted a subtle, pervasive archive of this systemic inequality and the psychological pain of marginalization.

C. The Auditory Archive of Power: Sounds of Imperial Presence and Control

The Ottoman state actively shaped the soundscape of Istanbul, using a repertoire of specific sounds—and strategic silences—to mark time, define territory, assert religious and military dominance, and continuously reinforce imperial authority in the daily lives of its diverse inhabitants.[18] This auditory environment functioned as an intangible yet powerful infrastructure of control, its echoes forming a persistent archive of imperial presence.

The daily calls to prayer, the *ezan*, broadcast five times a day from the minarets of countless mosques, most prominently the imperial mosques, served as the primary auditory marker of Islamic time and territorial dominance.[176] For the Muslim population, these sounds structured the day and affirmed religious identity; for non-Muslims, they were a constant reminder of the prevailing Islamic order.

The sounds of the Janissary Mehter bands were another potent auditory symbol of Ottoman military might.[18] Their distinctive, powerful music, characterized by a combination of bass drums, horns, zurnas, and cymbals, accompanied military campaigns, parades, and various state ceremonies.[23] The "crashing cymbals" of the Janissaries were described as a sound inspiring terror in enemies and awe in onlookers, audibly projecting the empire's military strength and discipline.[178] The regular patrols of Janissaries through the city streets would also have contributed to this sonic assertion of order and control.

Public proclamations of *fermans* (imperial decrees) and other official announcements were crucial for disseminating the Sultan's will and state laws.[20] While specific details about designated town criers (*münadi*) are limited in the provided sources, it is known that such decrees, bearing the Sultan's *tughra*, were formally read out.[142] These announcements, likely occurring in public spaces such as the Hippodrome (*Atmeydanı*) or the environs of major mosques, would have been an important auditory experience for the populace, conveying the

authority and reach of the state. The *ferman* itself, often an elaborately illuminated document, also served as a powerful visual symbol of imperial authority.[257]

Ceremonial cannon fire was another sound that punctuated the life of the capital, used to announce the Sultan's movements, significant state events, or religious celebrations, further marking imperial presence and power through loud, attention-grabbing auditory signals.[20] Conversely, the carefully orchestrated silence in the immediate presence of the Sultan, particularly within the inner court, was a profound auditory practice signifying his absolute authority, semi-divine status, and the timelessness of the dynasty.[19] This "staged silence" was a control mechanism, interrupting the normal temporal order and demanding reverence. The "pain" associated with this auditory infrastructure lies in its coercive nature, the constant reinforcement of an unchallengeable hierarchy, and the potential fear or awe these sounds (and silences) were designed to inspire, particularly among subjugated or marginalized groups. The collective memory of these sounds, and their association with imperial power, forms a significant auditory archive of Ottoman rule.

D. Systems of Sustenance and Social Order: Embodied Experiences of Provision and Control

The Ottoman Empire's systems of sustenance and social organization formed a complex infrastructure that simultaneously provided for certain segments of the population while extracting resources and labor from others, often entailing various forms of hardship and control. The memory and embodied experiences of these systems constitute a significant archive of imperial rule.

The **Timar system** was a foundational element of Ottoman military and economic organization, granting land revenues to military officers (*sipahis*) in exchange for their service and the provision of cavalrymen for the army.[155] This system created a direct link between land, military obligation, and the sustenance of the military class. However, the agricultural surplus that supported the *timariots* and *sipahis* was produced by the labor of the *re'aya* (peasants), who were tied to the land and subject to taxation.[155] This created a "somatic rhythm" of agricultural labor and military preparedness, where the toil of the peasantry formed the base of the imperial military structure. The hardship inherent in this extraction, and the potential for exploitation, represents a form of pain embedded within this system of sustenance.

The **Millet system** organized the empire's diverse non-Muslim subjects into autonomous religious communities, each governed by its own religious leaders and laws in matters of personal status.[99] While often lauded as a system of tolerance, it also served as an instrument of imperial control, reinforcing social hierarchies and the distinct status of non-Muslims as *dhimmi* (protected peoples) who paid specific taxes (like the *jizya*) and were subject to certain restrictions.[151] The psychological and social "pain" of this differentiated status, even under a regime of "tolerance," formed part of the lived experience for these communities. Guilds, which often crossed religious lines, regulated crafts and trades, providing a measure of economic organization and social security but also operating within the broader imperial framework of control.[249]

The **Janissary corps**, the elite infantry of the Ottoman army, was initially formed through the *devşirme* system—a levy of young Christian boys from Balkan provinces who were forcibly converted to Islam and trained for military or administrative service.[18] This practice, while creating a fiercely loyal and effective military force, inflicted profound trauma and suffering on the families and communities from which these boys were taken—a clear instance of pain being foundational to a key imperial infrastructure. The Janissaries themselves, though often rising to positions of power and privilege, carried the embodied archive of this violent uprooting and transformation. Their distinct uniforms and public presence were constant reminders of this unique system of recruitment and control.[18]

The establishment of **Imarets** (public soup kitchens), often part of larger *külliye* complexes, demonstrated imperial charity and provided essential sustenance to students, travelers, the poor, and even palace officials.[244] The provision of free food was a powerful symbol of the Sultan's benevolence and the state's concern for social welfare.[244] However, this system also created a degree of dependency and reinforced the legitimacy of Ottoman rule by positioning the Sultan as the ultimate provider. The act of receiving sustenance from the state, while alleviating hunger, also inscribed a relationship of obligation and underscored the hierarchical social order.

Ottoman court cuisine and elite feasting practices were markers of imperial splendor, cultural identity, and social status.[199] The elaborate dishes, preference for certain meats like mutton and lamb, use of specific grains like rice and bulgur, and the incorporation of costly spices such as pepper and cinnamon, created a distinct culinary tradition.[199] The evolution of banqueting customs, such as the 19th-century blending of traditional Ottoman (*alaturca*) and European (*alafranga*) styles, reflected changing cultural influences and imperial self-perception.[199] Access to such refined sustenance was a clear indicator of one's position within the imperial hierarchy, and the sensory experiences of these feasts formed an archive of elite privilege, contrasting with the plainer fare of the general populace. The Sultan's practice of eating alone and having food tasted for poison further highlighted the unique and guarded nature of supreme power.[275]

Collectively, these Ottoman systems of sustenance and social ordering created an infrastructure that was essential for the empire's functioning. This infrastructure, however, was intrinsically linked to the differential distribution of resources and the imposition of obligations that often involved hardship or the pain of separation and forced assimilation. The archive of this complex interplay of provision and control is found not only in economic records and architectural remains but also in the social memory of these institutions and the embodied experiences of those who lived under their sway.

V. Modeling Pain as Infrastructure: The Somatic Archive Across Empires

The comparative analysis of the Inca, Roman, and Ottoman Empires reveals compelling patterns in how pain was institutionalized as a fundamental component of imperial infrastructure, and how the resultant suffering was archived within the very fabric of these societies. While each empire manifested these dynamics through culturally specific forms, underlying commonalities suggest a broader model for understanding the relationship between power, pain, and memory in complex historical systems.

A. Comparative Analysis: Patterns and Manifestations of Systemic Suffering

Across these diverse empires, a consistent pattern emerges: the reliance on **coerced or obligatory labor** as a foundational element of imperial construction and maintenance. The Inca *Mita* system conscripted vast numbers of individuals for agriculture, road building (the *Qhapaq Ñan*), and other state projects, embedding the physical toll of this labor into the empire's monumental achievements.[11] Similarly, Roman *opera publica* utilized forced labor for the construction of its extensive road networks, aqueducts, and public buildings, the grandeur of which masked the often-unseen suffering of those who built them.[16] The Ottoman Timar system, while different in structure, relied on the agricultural labor of the *re'aya* to support the military class, integrating peasant toil into the very sinews of imperial defense and expansion.[155] In all cases, the pain of physical exertion, displacement, and often harsh conditions was an infrastructural necessity.

Another recurring manifestation of systemic suffering is **epistemicide**—the destruction of indigenous or pre-existing knowledge systems as a tool of conquest and control. The Spanish obliteration of the Inca *quipu*

system and the persecution of its keepers, the *Quipucamayocs*, stands as a stark example.[2] This act inflicted not only the pain of immediate violence but also the enduring suffering of cultural loss and the severance from ancestral ways of knowing. While the Roman and Ottoman empires often incorporated or adapted existing administrative systems, their imposition of a dominant language, legal framework, and religious worldview also involved the suppression or marginalization of local knowledges, creating archives of silenced voices and subjugated epistemologies. The burning of books in the Qin Dynasty, though different in context, shares this characteristic of state-sanctioned destruction of knowledge deemed threatening.[276] Similarly, the destruction of Nalanda University's library by invaders caused an immense loss of Buddhist philosophical, logical, and medical knowledge.[278]

The **ritualized display and normalization of violence** also appears as a common infrastructural element. Roman triumphal processions and gladiatorial games explicitly used the suffering of captives and combatants as public spectacle to affirm imperial power and entertain the masses.[15] The severe punishments meted out to Inca *chasquis* for failure served as a constant, terrifying reminder of the consequences of error, thereby ensuring the system's efficiency through fear.[13] Ottoman public ceremonies, while often emphasizing grandeur and benevolence, also occurred within a context where the Sultan's absolute power, including the power over life and death, was undisputed, creating a psychological infrastructure of control.[19]

Finally, **systems of sustenance and social ordering**, while providing for some, often created dependencies and reinforced hierarchies that were themselves forms of structural suffering. The Roman Annona, Ottoman *imarets*, and even the Inca redistribution system, while offering a degree of social security, also cemented the state's role as the ultimate provider and arbiter of resources, a subtle but pervasive form of control.[86] The Ottoman *devşirme* system is a particularly acute example where the "sustenance" (creation) of an elite military corps was directly predicated on the profound pain of separating children from their families and cultures.[18]

B. The Body as Archive: Trauma, Sensory Experience, and Somatic Memory

The concept of "Suffering as Archive" finds its most visceral manifestation in the human body itself. Trauma, whether from physical labor, violence, or psychological oppression, is not merely a mental event but is deeply inscribed in the body's physiology and memory.[3] The chronic pain, digestive issues, muscle tension, and sleep disturbances that can result from traumatic experiences are the body's way of archiving and expressing unresolved suffering.[4] Neurophysiological research indicates that pain experiences can lead to long-term potentiation in neural pathways, effectively encoding "pain memories" that can influence future cognitive processes and behavior, making the nervous system itself a repository of past suffering.[8]

In the context of the empires examined, the bodies of laborers under the *Mita* or *corvée* systems became archives of sustained physical stress and exhaustion. The *chasqui* runners, with their highly conditioned physiques and lungs adapted to extreme altitudes, and their reliance on coca to endure, literally embodied the demands of the imperial communication network; their potential for extreme punishment for failure was a constant somatic threat.[11] The sensory experiences of imperial subjects—the awe inspired by Roman monumental architecture, the sounds of Ottoman military bands or public decrees, the fear instilled by public punishments—all contributed to a somatic archive of imperial power, shaping their perceptions and behaviors.[3] The very act of "reading" an Inca *quipu*, a tactile and visual process [26], or the embodied knowledge required by a Roman architect to manipulate concrete and arches, represents somatic archives of cultural practice.

C. Infrastructure of Pain and Its Legacy: Enduring Archives

The infrastructures of pain established by these empires were not merely historical artifacts but systems that often had enduring legacies. The physical infrastructure—roads, buildings, aqueducts—remains in many cases, serving as a tangible archive of the labor, often coerced and painful, that created it. The *Qhapaq Ñan* is a prime example, its remnants still tracing paths across the Andes, a silent testament to Inca engineering and the *Mita* labor that built it.[63]

Beyond the physical, the social and psychological infrastructures of pain can also persist. The trauma of conquest, enslavement, or systemic discrimination can be transmitted across generations, becoming part of a community's collective memory and identity—an archive of suffering that continues to shape present realities.[5] The loss of the *quipu* knowledge system is not just a historical event for Andean communities; it is an ongoing absence, a cultural wound that informs contemporary identity and efforts towards cultural revitalization.[2] The memory of the *devşirme* system in the Balkans, or the legacy of Roman imperial law and administration, continues to echo in the regions once under Ottoman and Roman rule, respectively.

Therefore, modeling systems where suffering is the archive requires acknowledging that this archive is not static. It is continually being reinterpreted, contested, and sometimes reclaimed. The pain embedded in the infrastructure of past empires remains a potent force, shaping not only historical understanding but also contemporary social, cultural, and political landscapes. The effort to decipher *quipus*, to understand the lived experience of Roman plebeians, or to reconstruct the sensory world of Ottoman Istanbul are all attempts to engage with these enduring archives of suffering and, in doing so, to gain a more nuanced and complete understanding of the human cost of empire.

VI. Conclusion: The Enduring Resonance of Archived Suffering

The conceptualization of "Pain as Infrastructure" and "Suffering as Archive" offers a critical lens through which to re-examine the foundations and legacies of historical empires. The comparative analysis of the Inca, Roman, and Ottoman empires demonstrates that suffering, in its myriad forms—physical, psychological, and epistemic—was not merely an incidental byproduct of imperial rule but often a structural component, integral to the establishment, maintenance, and projection of power.

The Inca Empire's reliance on the *Mita* labor system, meticulously tracked by the *quipu* and enforced by the swift and disciplined *chasqui* network, illustrates how the physical pain of coerced labor and the psychological duress of strict control formed the bedrock of its impressive infrastructural and administrative achievements. The subsequent epistemicide of the *quipu* system by Spanish colonizers created a profound archive of loss, a cultural wound whose pain is archived in the collective memory and ongoing efforts to reclaim lost knowledge. The very bodies of the *chasquis*, conditioned for extreme endurance under threat of death, became living archives of imperial will.

The Roman Empire, through its monumental architecture built with corvée labor and its public spectacles of ritualized violence in triumphs and gladiatorial games, broadcast its dominance and archived its power in the sensory experiences of its populace. The Annona system, while providing sustenance, also underscored dependency. The pervasive visual and auditory symbols of authority—from legionary eagles and imperial coinage to public edicts—continuously reinforced Roman hegemony, creating an ambient archive of imperial ideology that was inescapable.

The Ottoman Empire utilized elaborate public ceremonies, the hierarchical design of its capital Istanbul, and a carefully managed soundscape to project imperial power and social order. Systems like the *devşirme*, which inflicted the pain of separation and forced assimilation to create the Janissary corps, and the Timar system, which tied military obligation to the toil of the peasantry, reveal how pain was woven into the fabric of imperial sustenance and control. The provision of food through *imarets* and the opulence of court cuisine further

demarcated social hierarchies, archiving status through differential access to sensory experiences.

Across these empires, the landscape itself often became a somatic archive, bearing the imprint of collective labor and suffering. The bodies of imperial subjects—whether laborers, messengers, soldiers, or the subjugated—served as repositories of trauma, resilience, and embodied knowledge. The destruction of knowledge systems, like the *quipu*, represents a particularly acute form of suffering, an epistemic violence whose legacy is an archive of enduring absence and pain.

The model of "Pain as Infrastructure" compels a shift in perspective, urging us to see suffering not as an anomaly but as a potential, often deliberate, constituent of systemic function. "Suffering as Archive" broadens our understanding of historical records beyond textual documents, recognizing the profound ways in which pain is inscribed in material culture, embodied memory, sensory landscapes, and cultural practices.

The enduring resonance of these archives of suffering is evident in contemporary efforts to recover lost histories, acknowledge past injustices, and understand the persistent impact of imperial legacies on present-day societies. By recognizing pain as an integral part of the infrastructure of past empires and suffering as a crucial, albeit often suppressed, archive, we gain a more complete and ethically engaged understanding of the human cost of power and the enduring weight of history. This framework underscores the importance of interdisciplinary approaches, drawing on anthropology, sociology, history, sensory studies, and trauma studies, to fully comprehend the complex ways in which suffering has shaped, and continues to shape, human societies. The echoes of these archives of pain challenge us to listen more attentively to the silenced voices of the past and to acknowledge the often-invisible infrastructures of suffering that may still operate in our contemporary world.

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